

Spain Itinerary – Aug 27 to Sep 12, 2026

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To Do Before You Leave

- ☐ Register for the Camino Frances / Pilgrim Pass at cms-pilgrim-pass.web.app/preregistration — needed for the QR code at Roncesvalles check-in (and other participating albergues).
- ☐ Get an eSIM or international data plan for Spain/France — needed for calling ahead to book each night's albergue as the trip goes.
- ☐ Confirm with El Palo de Avellano (Zubiri) whether a sleep sack/liner satisfies their “bring your own sleeping bag” requirement, or bring a compact 3-season bag instead.
- ☐ Book Pamplona lodging (Day 5, Aug 31).
- ☐ Book remaining Camino lodging day-by-day as the trip progresses (Puente la Reina through Burgos).
- ☐ Book Burgos → Madrid transport for Sep 10.
- ☐ Book Madrid lodging for the night of Sep 10.

Itinerary

Day 1 – Thu Aug 27

- ~9:00 am — Leave Grand Rapids (drop Gus off at Tisha's) → Todd's house, 5739 S Franklin Ave, La Grange Highlands, IL (~2h45m–3h15m normally; budget 3h30m for Chicago-area traffic)
- ~12:55–1:00 pm — Arrive Todd's
- ~1:15 pm — Uber Todd's house → ORD (~20–25 min drive; budget ~45 min total).
- ~2:00 pm — Arrive ORD Terminal 5 (~3 hrs before departure).
- Chicago ORD → Madrid: **Iberia IB 342**, dep 4:55 pm, arr Aug 28 8:20 am.

Day 2 – Fri Aug 28

- 08:20 — Land Madrid Barajas T4; passport control + bags.
- ~08:55 — Cercanías C1, “Aeropuerto T4” → Atocha (~30 min).
- ~09:30 — Arrive Atocha; security/bag check for the ALVIA departure.
- 10:32 — Depart Atocha → Pamplona/Iruña: **ALVIA 00605**, Coche 1 / Asiento 10C
- 13:59 — Arrive Pamplona/Iruña.
- Taxi from the station rank (Plaza de la Estación) → Saint-Jean-Pied-de-Port (~1h12m). Fixed/regulated fare, not metered: ~€104–120 weekday daytime. Local Pamplona radio-taxi dispatch (24h) if the rank is empty: +34 948 23 23 00 / +34 948 35 13 35.
- ~15:10–15:15 — Estimated arrival Saint-Jean-Pied-de-Port.
- Check-in: **Gîte de la Porte Saint Jacques**, 51 rue de la Citadelle, Saint-Jean-Pied-de-Port, France 64220.
- Pick up pilgrim credential in SJPP if not already obtained.

Day 3 – Sat Aug 29 (Camino Day 1)

- **Saint-Jean-Pied-de-Port → Roncesvalles** (~25 km / 15.5 mi) — the Napoleon Route over the Pyrenees.
 - Route highlights: steep climb out of SJPP past Refuge Orisson; the Virgin of Biakorri statue; the high ridge crossing the France–Spain border with sweeping Pyrenees views; descent through beech forest at Col de Lepoeder into Roncesvalles’ Collegiate Church and monastery.
- Show QR code / passport at check-in. Dinner seating 20:30. Doors close 22:00; reservation held until 19:00 unless later arrival is flagged.
- Overnight: **Albergue de Peregrinos de Orreaga-Roncesvalles**, Carretera N-135 s/n, Roncesvalles, Navarra 31650. Phone +34 948 760 000 | info@alberguederoncesvalles.com | www.alberguederoncesvalles.com. Localizador **AL08344890**, €35 (alojamiento, cena y desayuno)

Caution

This is the hardest and most exposed day of the entire Camino (~1,200 m climb, few bailout points), done one day after a transatlantic flight and jet lag. Start at first light. Check weather the night before — in fog, high wind, or rain, take the lower **Valcarlos route** instead (~19 km, road-based, far less exposure); ask at the SJPP pilgrim office. Carry rain layer, poles, and food/water since services on the Napoleon route are minimal.

Day 4 – Sun Aug 30 (Camino Day 2)

- **Roncesvalles → Zubiri** (~21.5 km / 13.4 mi)
 - Route highlights: descent through Auritz/Burguete (the village where Hemingway stayed and wrote of trout fishing in *The Sun Also Rises*); Roncesvalles pass and Erro valley beech forest; Alto de Erro; drop into Zubiri over the medieval Puente de la Rabia.
- Overnight: **Albergue El Palo de Avellano**, Avenida Roncesvalles 16, Zubiri, Navarra 31630. Phone +34 666 499 175 | info@elpalodeavellano.com. (breakfast included). No prepayment — pay at property, card held as guarantee; free cancel/modify up to 24 hrs before arrival. Reception 13:00–18:00; main door locks at 22:00 (key-card access after); check-out before 9:00; call ahead if arriving after 3pm. Bring a sleeping bag (sheets rentable, €3).

Day 5 – Mon Aug 31 (Camino Day 3)

- **Zubiri → Pamplona** (~20.4 km / 12.7 mi)
 - Route highlights: riverside path along the Río Arga; Larrasoana; the Romanesque Trinidad de Arre bridge marking the entry into greater Pamplona; Pamplona's old town, Plaza del Castillo, and the Gothic cathedral.
- Lodging: not yet booked. Pamplona is a real city with plenty of hotels/hostels beyond pilgrim albergues — lower urgency than Zubiri, but book when convenient.

Day 6 – Tue Sep 1 (Camino Day 4)

- **Pamplona → Puente la Reina** (~23.8 km / 14.8 mi)
 - Route highlights: Alto del Perdón ridge — wind turbines and the famous silhouette-of-pilgrims sculpture with panoramic views over Navarra; Uterga and Muruzábal; Puente la Reina's iconic 11th-century Romanesque bridge, where the Camino Francés and Camino Aragonés merge.
- Lodging: not yet booked.

Day 7 – Wed Sep 2 (Camino Day 5)

- **Puente la Reina → Estella** (~21.5 km / 13.4 mi)
 - Route highlights: hilltop medieval village of Cirauqui with a stretch of original Roman road below it; Lorca and Villatuerta; Estella/Lizarra's Palacio de los Reyes de Navarra and the church of San Pedro de la Rúa.
- Lodging: not yet booked.

Day 8 – Thu Sep 3 (Camino Day 6)

- **Estella → Los Arcos** (~21.3 km / 13.2 mi)
 - Route highlights: Bodegas Irache's free pilgrim wine fountain (Fuente del Vino) right on the trail; Monasterio de Irache; Villamayor de Monjardín beneath its hilltop castle ruins; Los Arcos and the ornate church of Santa María.
- Lodging: not yet booked.

Day 9 – Fri Sep 4 (Camino Day 7)

- **Los Arcos → Logroño** (~27.5 km / 17.1 mi) — long and largely shadeless through vineyard country; start at dawn.
 - Route highlights: Sansol and Torres del Río’s octagonal, Templar-linked Church of the Holy Sepulchre; crossing from Navarra into La Rioja; Viana’s old town; entering Logroño — Rioja’s wine capital — over the Puente de Piedra and into the Calle Laurel tapas district.
- Lodging: not yet booked.

Day 10 – Sat Sep 5 (Camino Day 8)

- **Logroño → Nájera** (~29 km / 18.0 mi) — longest stage of the trip, same exposed terrain; start at dawn, carry extra water.
 - Route highlights: Parque de la Grajera reservoir just outside Logroño; Navarrete’s vineyards and pottery tradition; Nájera’s cliffside setting above the Río Najerilla and the royal pantheon in the Monasterio de Santa María la Real.
- Lodging: not yet booked.

Day 11 – Sun Sep 6 (Camino Day 9)

- **Nájera → Santo Domingo de la Calzada** (~21 km / 13.0 mi)
 - Route highlights: Azofra and Cirueña; Santo Domingo de la Calzada’s cathedral, famous for keeping a live rooster and hen inside in honor of the town’s “hanged pilgrim” legend.
- Lodging: not yet booked.

Day 12 – Mon Sep 7 (Camino Day 10)

- **Santo Domingo de la Calzada → Belorado** (~22.8 km / 14.2 mi)
 - Route highlights: hilltop Grañón with views back over the Rioja plain; crossing from La Rioja into Castilla y León near Redecilla del Camino; Vitoria de Rioja, birthplace of Santo Domingo; Belorado’s old quarter and nearby cave dwellings.
- Lodging: not yet booked.

Day 13 – Tue Sep 8 (Camino Day 11)

- **Belorado → San Juan de Ortega** (~23.7 km / 14.7 mi)
 - Route highlights: Villafranca Montes de Oca, the last village before a long climb into the Montes de Oca oak and pine forest (historically the most dangerous stretch of the Camino for robbers); the remote Romanesque monastery at San Juan de Ortega, known for a twice-yearly light phenomenon illuminating a capital inside the church at the equinoxes.
- Lodging: not yet booked.

Day 14 – Wed Sep 9 (Camino Day 12)

- **San Juan de Ortega → Burgos** (~25.8 km / 16.0 mi)
 - Route highlights: Agés and Atapuerca, site of a UNESCO World Heritage archaeological complex with some of the oldest hominid fossils in Europe; the terrain opens into flatter farmland on the approach to Burgos (a preview of the Meseta beyond); Burgos's Gothic cathedral — a UNESCO World Heritage Site — and El Cid's tomb in the old town.
- Lodging: not yet booked.

Day 15 – Thu Sep 10

- Burgos → Madrid (train/bus, ~2.5–3 hrs) — not yet booked; book once the walking pace through Day 14 is confirmed.
- Overnight near Madrid — not yet booked.

Day 16 – Fri Sep 11

- Madrid → Chicago ORD: **Iberia IB 341**, dep 11:45 am, arr 2:25 pm.
- Uber ORD → Todd's house, La Grange Highlands, IL (~20–25 min); overnight at Todd's.

Day 17 – Sat Sep 12

- Drive Todd's house → Grand Rapids (~2h45m–3h15m).

Packing List

Documents & Money

- Passport
- Pilgrim credential (credencial)
- Credit + ATM cards
- Euro cash

Pack Setup

- Backpack with rain cover (35–40L)
- 1 small dry sack (electronics/passport)
- Packing cubes + plastic bags (organization, laundry separation)

Clothing

- 2 quick-dry short-sleeve tees (Patagonia Capilene)
- 1 long-sleeve thermal / light layer (Smartwool 150)
- 1 light fleece or packable insulated layer (Patagonia)
- 1 lightweight rain jacket
- 1 convertible hiking pant
- 1 pair town/casual pants or shorts
- 3 pairs quick-dry underwear
- 3 pairs hiking socks (merino blend)

Footwear

- Trail runners or light hiking shoes (Altra Lone Peak)
- Lightweight sandals (Xero Z-Trek)

Toiletries

- Toothbrush + travel toothpaste
- Small liquid soap (body + laundry, e.g. Dr. Bronner's)
- Travel deodorant
- Quick-dry towel (PackTowel)
- Sunscreen
- Lip balm with SPF

Health & First Aid

- Blister pads (Compeed-style hydrocolloid)
- Ibuprofen / acetaminophen / personal medications
- Earplugs + eye mask (shared albergue dorms)
- Trekking poles (recommended for the SJPP–Roncesvalles descent)

Electronics

- iPhone + USB-C cord
- EU plug adapter
- AirPods
- Macbook Air
- Portable power bank

Other

- Sunglasses
- Hat
- Sleep sack
- $2 \times 1\text{L}$ water bottles
- Pen